



SIPRA DAS

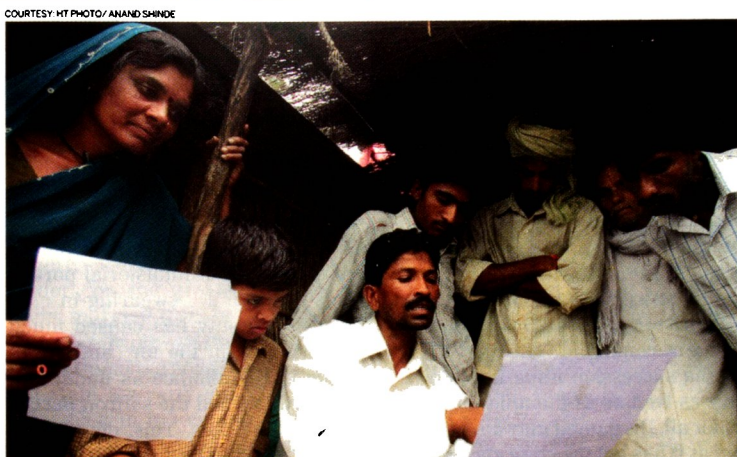
Season of Giving

- Scheme: Jeevandayi Yojana Scheme. Offers free treatment (surgery for life-threatening disorders) for students in anganwadis and zilla parishad schools
Amount: **Rs 45 crore** this year and Rs 65 crore henceforth
Impact: Will benefit poor students
- Scheme: A package for farmers who have not benefited from the Centre's loan waiver
Amount: **Rs 6,208 crore**
Impact: Will benefit 40 lakh farmers
- Scheme: Grant to Nagpur University to spread the teachings of local saint Rashtrasant Tukadoji
Amount: **Rs 2 crore**
Impact: Funds will be used for the development of the university
- Scheme: Children of underprivileged farmers in Vidarbha to get free education from Class 1 to 12
Amount: **Not available**
Impact: Will benefit 4,34,291 families
- Scheme: Digging of wells and repair of dams and lakes in 11 districts of Vidarbha
Amount: **Rs 1,000 crore** in the first phase
Impact: Will impact farmers of Vidarbha but depends on the efficiency of the local administration

loan waiver yet to cover all the beneficiaries, the Government has found another way to appease farmers. Following protests from farmers who were left out of the loan waiver, the Government has announced a Rs 6,208-crore package for over 23 lakh farmers who were ineligible under the earlier schemes. It works like this—those with a loan of up to Rs 20,000 get a total waiver; for those falling into a higher loan bracket, the Government will offer a compensation of Rs 20,000 if they clear their dues by June 30, 2009. State politicians say that the move has been at the behest of the NCP, which holds the agriculture portfolio. "The NCP has high stakes in the general elections. This is only to win over the rural votes," says Tawde.

The blame game is not restricted to the coalition partners. Political one-upmanship is evident within the Congress as well. Chief Minister Ashok Chavan's proposal to carve out a new revenue division and set up its headquarters in Nanded is seen as a move to be one up on his predecessor Vilasrao Deshmukh who was pushing for a division in his hometown Latur. The matter has now snowballed into a political controversy, creating cliques within the state Congress. "Chavan now wants to prove his supremacy in state matters. The location of the commissioner's office is inconsequential as a new division was the need of the hour. It has only become an ego clash between politicians who want to please their own constituency," says a state government official.

Despite criticism from various quarters, the DF Government is falling back on populist schemes. "It's a regular poll-time strategy. Once announced, no one bothers to see when the schemes are actually implemented. Also the feeling is that the next government will bear the burden of the deficit," says a senior bureaucrat. With polls only a few months away, it won't be too long before Maharashtra decides whether to vote for these populist measures or not. ■



COURTESY: HT PHOTO/ANAND SHINDE